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Chess is an individual sport by nature, but the excitement and dynamics of playing it in a team format elevate the Olympiad to a unique and special status. This year, the world's biggest multi-national chess tournament returns to Budapest for the first time since 1926, with the 45th Chess Olympiad set to take place in Hungary from September 10 to 23.

A total of 193 teams in the Open section and 181 in the Women's will

battle it out over 11 rounds of the Swiss format for a chance at a podium finish. India, which hosted the previous edition, bagged bronze medals in both sections and will be looking to build on that success.

With an average rating of 2755, India enters the open section as the second-seeded team, just behind the USA (2758). It boasts a supremely talented lineup, including world championship challenger D. Gukesh, world No. 4 Arjun Erigaisi, and world No. 12 R. Praggnanandhaa. They are well supported by the experienced shoulders of Vidit Gujrathi and Pentala Harikrishna, making India one of the strongest contenders.

Bragging rights: D. Gukesh will meet defending champion, China's Ding Liren, in a 14-game series for the world crown from November 20 to December 15. LENNART OOTES

Having secured bronze medals in 2014 and 2022, India will pin its hope on this dynamic team to clinch its first gold medal at an on-the-board tournament. India did share a gold medal with Russia at the 2020 Olympiad, albeit in a COVID-19-induced online event.

This tournament also serves as a crucial preparation ground for Gukesh, who is set to challenge China's Ding Liren for the world championship title in less than three months.

Gukesh recently made history by becoming the youngest-ever World Championship challenger, securing his spot by winning the Candidates' tournament in Toronto earlier this year.

Although Praggnanandhaa finished fifth at the Candidates', he went on to beat World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen for the first time in over-the-board en route to a podium finish at the prestigious Norway Chess.

However, it's Arjun who has truly stolen the spotlight. Dominating open events, Arjun's meteoric rise has earned him the title of India's new No. 1, bringing him tantalisingly close to the coveted 2800 Elo rating mark.

On the other hand, the last two boards — Vidit and Harikrishna — could pose a potential vulnerability for India at the Olympiad due to their recent inactivity. Vidit took an extended break following a disappointing Candidates' campaign, while Harikrishna, who has slipped to India's No. 7, has only participated in a handful of events, resulting in a significant drop in his rating, now well below 2700, placing him behind Aravindh and Chithambaram.

To support the Indian team's preparation, the All India Chess Federation (AICF) has enlisted Srinath Narayanan, known for his calm demeanour and strong